

PARAYA - Follow-up Questions (CCS - Villanueva)

PARAYA Officer Roles

1. Beside the Director, what are the other roles that exist within PARAYA office?

Besides the Director, the PARAYA Office is composed of an Office Associate and a Researcher, each playing an important role in ensuring that the office's programs and community initiatives are properly implemented.

2. Can you specify what that specific role does?

The Office Associate mainly assists in the day-to-day administrative operations of the office, such as coordinating activities, managing communications, and helping organize outreach programs and partnerships. Meanwhile, the Researcher focuses on evaluating data, conducting studies, and assessing community needs to ensure that the office's projects are responsive, relevant, and evidence-based.

Although the office has a relatively small core team, PARAYA greatly relies on collaboration and volunteerism. Since it is centered on community engagement and extension work, the office actively encourages volunteers from different groups inside the institution and sectors to participate in its initiatives. These volunteers contribute their skills, time, and expertise in various activities, allowing the office to expand its reach and strengthen its impact within the communities it serves.

3. Do all officers have access to all the process and data of PARAYA (ex. Budget allotted for a program)

Generally, the officers within PARAYA are expected to have an understanding of the processes and operational flow of the office, especially since collaboration and coordination are essential in carrying out community engagement programs effectively. The office promotes a proactive working environment where communication and awareness among officers are highly encouraged.

PHASES

Phase I: Diagnostic Observation & Environmental Scanning

1. Is there a standardized observation checklist or is it open-ended when conducting observations?

When conducting observations, PARAYA generally follows a more open-ended approach rather than relying solely on a standardized observation checklist. In research and scientific inquiry, everything often begins with simple observations of what is happening within society and the community. These observations allow researchers and volunteers to identify existing issues, recurring situations, and areas where intervention or engagement may be needed.

Because community concerns and social conditions can vary greatly, the office values flexibility in the observation process. An open-ended approach enables researchers and community workers to gather more authentic insights, understand the context more deeply, and recognize concerns that may not immediately appear within a fixed checklist.

However, while the observations are generally open-ended, there are still guiding objectives and frameworks depending on the nature of the project or program being conducted. This helps ensure that the gathered information remains relevant, organized, and aligned with the goals of the research or community initiative.

Phase II: Problem Posing & Objective Formulation

1. Are the objectives co-created with community stakeholders, or are they formulated internally and then presented?

The formulation of objectives in PARAYA is primarily guided internally by the project team, in alignment with the institution's vision, mission, and identified priorities. This ensures that proposals remain consistent with the overall mandate of the office and the strategic direction of the administration.

However, this process is not entirely one-directional. Community stakeholders are still meaningfully engaged, especially during the needs assessment and consultation phases, where their inputs help shape the direction, focus, and relevance of the proposed objectives. In this sense, their perspectives are integrated into the planning process before finalization.

Once a draft of the objectives is developed internally, it is often presented to stakeholders for validation and feedback. This allows for adjustments based on community realities, ensuring that the final objectives are both institutionally aligned and contextually grounded.

So, while the technical formulation is led internally, the process remains participatory, with community engagement playing a crucial role in refining and validating the objectives before implementation.

2. Do you use a specific framework for writing objectives (e.g., SMART goals), and how many objectives typically guide a single project?

When formulating objectives for projects and initiatives, PARAYA primarily aligns its goals with the vision and mission of the institution. Since the office operates under the administration of the school, its programs are designed to reflect the institution's core values, developmental goals, and commitment to community engagement and social responsibility.

Rather than focusing solely on rigid frameworks, the office ensures that every objective is purposeful, community-centered, and sustainable. The initiatives are not intended to be

short-term or one-time efforts; instead, they are carefully planned to create long-lasting impact and continuous development within the communities being served. Sustainability is a major consideration in designing projects, ensuring that programs can continue to benefit stakeholders even beyond the initial implementation stage.

In terms of the number of objectives, this usually depends on the scale and nature of the project. However, each initiative is generally guided by a set of clear and achievable objectives that support both the institution's mission and the specific needs of the community. Ultimately, the goal is to ensure that every project remains meaningful, responsive, and capable of producing sustainable outcomes.

Phase III: Research Design & Methodology

1. How do you determine whether a project calls for quantitative tools, qualitative tools, or both? Is there a decision tree for that?

The choice between quantitative tools, qualitative tools, or a combination of both primarily depends on the nature of the project, the objectives of the study, and the kind of information that the office intends to gather. Rather than strictly following a fixed decision tree, PARAYA approaches each project based on the needs of the community and the specific outcomes being targeted.

If the project requires measurable data, statistical analysis, or numerical evidence—such as determining the number of beneficiaries, measuring participation rates, or assessing the extent of a community concern—then quantitative tools are commonly utilized. On the other hand, if the initiative seeks to understand personal experiences, perceptions, behaviors, or deeper social contexts, qualitative tools such as interviews, focus group discussions, and open-ended observations become more appropriate.

In many cases, the office may also employ a mixed-method approach, combining both quantitative and qualitative tools to achieve a more comprehensive understanding of the situation. This allows the office not only to gather factual and measurable information, but also to capture the human experiences and realities behind the data.

At long last, the decision is guided by the purpose of the project and the kind of impact or insight the office hopes to achieve, ensuring that the chosen methodology remains relevant, responsive, and aligned with the objectives of the initiative.

2. Are the instruments (Likert scales, FGD protocols) developed fresh each time, or do you maintain a standardized toolkit that gets adapted per project?

The instruments used in PARAYA, such as Likert scales, survey questionnaires, and FGD or interview protocols, are not necessarily created entirely from scratch every time. In many

cases, the office maintains guiding frameworks or standardized tools that can serve as references or foundations for different projects.

However, these instruments are usually adapted and contextualized depending on the nature of the project, the target community, and the objectives of the initiative. Since community concerns and research contexts vary, the office recognizes the importance of modifying instruments to ensure that the questions, indicators, and methods remain relevant, understandable, and responsive to the actual situation being studied.

For example, a Likert scale or FGD guide used in one community engagement project may still provide a structural basis for another initiative, but certain items, themes, or indicators may be revised to better capture the specific experiences and needs of the participants involved.

This approach allows the office to maintain consistency and methodological reliability while also ensuring flexibility and contextual sensitivity in data gathering. When all is said and done, the goal is to create instruments that are both research-based and community-responsive.

Phase IV: Data Collection & Data Cleaning

1. What's your threshold or criteria for identifying an "outlier" or "inconsistent response" during data scrubbing? Who makes that judgment call, and is it documented?

When identifying outliers or inconsistent responses during data scrubbing, the office generally considers responses that appear highly unusual, contradictory, incomplete, or significantly outside the expected pattern of the gathered data. These may include answers that do not align with the objectives of the study, responses with obvious inconsistencies, or data entries that could potentially affect the accuracy and reliability of the results.

However, determining whether a response is truly an outlier is not based solely on personal judgment. The process is usually guided by the methodology, research objectives, and the standards established for the project. In quantitative studies, statistical indicators and patterns may be used to identify unusual data points, while in qualitative research, inconsistencies are often assessed through contextual analysis and validation of responses.

The responsibility for making these judgment calls typically falls under the researchers to ensure objectivity and fairness in the process. Moreover, the office values transparency and accountability, so decisions related to data cleaning, exclusion of responses, or adjustments in the dataset are ideally documented as part of the research process. This documentation helps maintain the integrity, credibility, and reproducibility of the study while ensuring that the conclusions drawn are based on reliable and ethically handled data.

2. For thematic analysis, do you follow a specific established method, and how many coders are involved to ensure inter-rater reliability?

When conducting thematic analysis, the office generally follows established qualitative research principles to ensure that the interpretation of data remains systematic, credible, and aligned with the objectives of the study. The process usually involves familiarizing with the gathered data, identifying recurring patterns or significant statements, grouping these into themes, and interpreting how these themes relate to the research problem or community concern being addressed.

Rather than relying on a purely subjective interpretation, the office encourages collaborative analysis among members of the research team. Multiple researchers or coders may be involved in reviewing the data in order to strengthen reliability and minimize individual bias. Having more than one coder allows the team to compare interpretations, validate emerging themes, and ensure that the findings are grounded in the actual responses of the participants.

The exact number of coders may vary depending on the scale and complexity of the project, as well as the available personnel within the office. However, the goal is always to maintain consistency, objectivity, and credibility in the analysis process. Discussions, consultations, and cross-checking among the research team are important practices to help establish inter-rater reliability and ensure that the resulting themes accurately reflect the data collected.

3. When quantitative and qualitative findings contradict each other, how do you reconcile them in the synthesis step?

When quantitative and qualitative findings appear to contradict each other, the office does not immediately treat one as invalid over the other. Instead, this situation is approached as an important point for deeper analysis and interpretation, since mixed-method findings are meant to provide a more comprehensive understanding of the issue.

In the synthesis stage, the first step is to carefully revisit both datasets to ensure that there are no issues in data collection, coding, or interpretation. Once the integrity of the data is confirmed, the team then examines the context behind the discrepancy. Quantitative data may show general trends or patterns, while qualitative data often provides the lived experiences and explanations behind those numbers.

The reconciliation process usually involves triangulation—comparing both sets of findings to identify where they align, diverge, and why such differences may exist. These contradictions are not necessarily seen as errors, but rather as meaningful insights that may highlight complexity within the community or variability among respondents.

Instead of forcing the results to align, the office presents a balanced interpretation that acknowledges both perspectives. The synthesis emphasizes explanation over contradiction, ensuring that the final conclusion reflects the full depth of the data and provides a more nuanced understanding of the research problem.

4. At what point are community members re-engaged to validate or challenge the interpretation of findings?

Community members are typically re-engaged after the initial analysis and synthesis of findings, during what is often referred to as the validation or feedback stage of the research process. At this point, preliminary results have already been organized into themes, patterns, or key insights, but they are not yet considered final.

The purpose of this stage is to ensure that the interpretations accurately reflect the lived experiences, perspectives, and realities of the community. Through activities such as feedback sessions, consultations, or presentations, community members are given the opportunity to confirm, clarify, or challenge the findings. This helps identify possible misinterpretations, missing context, or areas that require further explanation.

This re-engagement is an important part of participatory and community-centered research, as it strengthens the credibility and relevance of the study. It also ensures that the voices of the community are not only captured during data collection but are also respected and reflected in the final interpretation of results.

Basically, this step serves as a form of validation and co-construction of knowledge, where both the researchers and the community contribute to refining the final output before it is formally concluded or disseminated.

Phase VI: Conclusion, Recommendation, and Filing

1. What does the "technical review" by the Head of Paraya Office specifically evaluate? (methodological rigor, feasibility, budget, or all of the above?)

The technical review conducted by the Head of the PARAYA Office is comprehensive in nature and typically evaluates multiple critical aspects of a proposed project. It is not limited to a single dimension, but rather ensures that the initiative is sound both in theory and in implementation.

Primarily, it assesses methodological rigor—checking whether the proposed approach is appropriate, systematic, and aligned with accepted research and community engagement standards. This includes evaluating the clarity of objectives, the suitability of tools and methods, and the overall coherence of the project design.

In addition, feasibility is also carefully reviewed, particularly in terms of whether the project can realistically be implemented within the given timeframe, available manpower, and operational constraints. This ensures that the proposal is not only well-designed but also practical and executable.

Budget considerations are likewise part of the review process, especially in relation to whether the proposed financial requirements are reasonable, justified, and aligned with institutional guidelines and available resources.

Overall, the technical review serves as a quality control mechanism that ensures proposals are methodologically sound, feasible to implement, and financially responsible, thereby increasing the likelihood of successful and sustainable project outcomes.

2. What happens if the Office of the President or administration rejects or significantly modifies the proposal? Is there a revision loop back to an earlier phase?

If a proposal is rejected or significantly modified by the Office of the President or the administration, it is not immediately discarded. Instead, it goes through a revision process where the feedback provided becomes the basis for improving and refining the proposal.

In most cases, the proposal is returned to the PARAYA Office or the project proponents, who then carefully review the comments, identify the required adjustments, and revise the document accordingly. This may involve revisiting earlier stages of planning—such as the objectives, methodology, implementation design, or budget—to ensure that the concerns raised are properly addressed.

Yes, this effectively functions as a revision loop that brings the proposal back to an earlier phase of the planning cycle. The goal is to strengthen the proposal rather than restart from zero, ensuring that it becomes more aligned with institutional priorities, administrative standards, and feasibility requirements.

After revisions are made, the updated proposal is resubmitted for another round of review until it meets the necessary approval standards. This iterative process helps ensure that all approved projects are well-aligned, realistic, and sustainable in implementation.

3. How are past filed reports used? Is there a knowledge management system, or does each project start relatively fresh?

Past filed reports are treated as important institutional references rather than isolated documents that are set aside after completion. They serve as a form of knowledge base that can inform the design, implementation, and evaluation of future projects.

In practice, new proposals and initiatives are not developed entirely from scratch. Instead, teams often review previous reports to understand what strategies were effective, what challenges were encountered, and what recommendations were made. This helps ensure continuity, learning, and improvement across successive projects.

While the extent of a formalized knowledge management system may vary, the general practice within the office is to maintain organized documentation of reports, which can be accessed for reference during planning and review stages. This allows the office to build on existing insights rather than repeat past inefficiencies.

Ultimately, past reports function as a learning repository that supports evidence-based planning, strengthens institutional memory, and helps ensure that future projects are more refined, efficient, and impactful.

Phase VII: Strategic Planning & Execution

1. What role does the community itself play during execution — passive beneficiaries or active co-implementors?

The community is not treated as passive beneficiaries in PARAYA's implementation process. Instead, they play an active and participatory role as co-implementors of the programs and initiatives. This means that community members are involved not only in receiving services or outputs, but also in the actual execution of activities—such as organizing events, participating in decision-making during implementation, contributing local knowledge, and helping ensure that the programs are responsive to their real needs and context.

By positioning the community as co-implementors, the office strengthens ownership and accountability on the ground. This approach also helps ensure that initiatives are more grounded, culturally appropriate, and sustainable, since the people directly affected are actively engaged in shaping how the program is carried out. This participatory setup reflects the core principle of community engagement: that development work is most effective when it is done with the community, not just for the community.

2. How is the transition from approved proposal to operational plan managed?

The transition from an approved proposal to an operational plan is managed through a structured translation of the proposal's objectives into actionable steps. Once a project is approved, the focus shifts from conceptual planning to detailed implementation planning.

At this stage, the approved proposal is broken down into specific activities, timelines, assigned responsibilities, resource requirements, and logistical arrangements. This ensures that each component of the project is clearly operationalized and ready for execution. Coordination

among the project team, Office Associate, and relevant stakeholders is crucial during this phase to align expectations and clarify roles.

The operational plan also serves as a more practical guide for implementation, often including work schedules, task assignments, communication flow, and monitoring mechanisms. Budget allocations, if already approved, are also aligned with the operational activities to ensure proper utilization of resources.

Overall, this transition is carefully managed to ensure continuity between planning and execution, minimizing gaps or misinterpretations, and ensuring that the approved objectives are effectively translated into concrete, organized, and achievable actions on the ground.

Phase VIII: Post-Implementation Assessment

1. How soon after implementation does the impact assessment occur, and do you conduct both immediate and long-term follow-ups?

Impact assessment is typically conducted in stages rather than at a single fixed point after implementation. An initial or immediate assessment is often done shortly after the completion of the activity or program, primarily to capture immediate outputs, participant feedback, and short-term outcomes. This helps determine whether the project was implemented as planned and whether it achieved its immediate objectives.

In addition to this, the office also recognizes the importance of longer-term follow-ups. Depending on the nature of the project, a secondary or delayed assessment may be conducted weeks or even months after implementation to evaluate sustained outcomes and actual community impact. This allows the office to determine whether the initiative has led to meaningful and lasting changes within the community.

The timing of these assessments may vary per project, as it is usually guided by the objectives, available resources, and the expected duration of impact. However, the general approach emphasizes both immediate and long-term evaluation to ensure a more comprehensive understanding of effectiveness.

This staged assessment process helps the office not only measure success at the point of implementation but also understand the enduring value and sustainability of its programs.

2. What specific metrics or indicators define "effectiveness"? are these pre-established during Phase II?

Effectiveness in PARAYA projects is defined through a combination of pre-established indicators and project-specific measures that are aligned with the objectives set during the

planning phase, particularly Phase II. These indicators are not arbitrary; they are carefully identified early in the process to ensure that evaluation is grounded and measurable.

Typically, effectiveness is assessed using both quantitative and qualitative indicators. Quantitative measures may include participation rates, completion rates, level of engagement, or achievement of target outputs. Meanwhile, qualitative indicators focus on changes in awareness, behavior, satisfaction, perceived relevance, and the overall experience of the stakeholders or community members involved.

Yes, these indicators are generally established during Phase II, where the objectives and evaluation framework of the project are being defined. This ensures that there is a clear basis for monitoring and assessing whether the project has met its intended goals once implementation begins.

However, while the core indicators are pre-established, there is still some level of flexibility to adjust or refine them depending on contextual realities that may emerge during implementation. Effectiveness is defined not only by whether targets are met, but also by the extent to which the project produces meaningful, relevant, and sustainable impact in the community it serves.

3. How concretely does the feedback loop work? Is there a formal mechanism that channels Phase VIII findings back into Phase I for the next cycle, or is it informal?

The feedback loop in PARAYA is designed to function as a structured but adaptive system, rather than an entirely informal process. Findings from Phase VIII, which typically involves evaluation and impact assessment, are documented and consolidated into formal reports. These reports serve as the primary mechanism for channeling insights back into the planning cycle.

Concretely, the results, recommendations, and identified gaps from Phase VIII are reviewed and discussed by the office during post-implementation assessments or internal debriefing sessions. These outputs are then used as reference inputs for Phase I of the next cycle, particularly in identifying new priorities, refining objectives, and improving project design.

While there is a formal documentation process that ensures continuity of learning, the application of feedback can also be iterative and contextual. In practice, it is a combination of structured reporting and guided institutional reflection, where lessons learned are intentionally integrated into future planning rather than left as standalone records.

Ultimately, the system functions as a semi-formal feedback mechanism—anchored on documented outputs but reinforced through institutional practice—ensuring that each new cycle benefits from the evidence and experiences of previous implementations.

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